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At the boardinghouse, after the sisters had changed, brushed their teeth and washed their faces, they turned off the light and huddled close in bed. Moonlight shone through the thin curtains. Léa could see Rose's eyes wide open, fixed on the sky outside. She stroked her sister's arm. "That was a wonderful day, and the LeBlanc family was so welcoming."

"It was the best day of my life," said Rose.

"Because of the lunch?"

"Partly—the cornbread was delicious and the tomatoes were so fresh." Rose turned to her sister. "What do you think of André?"

"I like him. He seems genuine and kind."

"He is. Can I ask you something?"

"Sure."

"Have you ever been kissed?"

Léa sat up on one elbow. "Did André kiss you?"

"No. But I could feel he *wanted* to." She covered her mouth with her hand. "And I wanted him to kiss me too!"

Léa rested her head on her arm. Rose was growing up so quickly. "What do you mean you could feel it?"

She usually shut such thoughts away. Wanting to be kissed seemed pointless.

Rose closed her eyes. "It's like looking at the sky at dawn, all that color—yellow, orange, blue—it stirs your soul." She opened her eyes.

"Your soul?" Now, it was Léa's turn to giggle. "From the anticipation of a kiss?"

"Don't laugh! You'll know what I mean when it happens to you."

"You make it sound so serious." Léa smiled.

"Love is serious."

"I disagree." Léa suddenly stiffened. "Working, taking care of family, responsibilities, that is what's serious."

Rose turned to her. "But how can you do those things without love?"

Rose was right, in terms of family—Léa loved her sister, which is why she cared for her. But for her, love between a man and a woman was a choice, not a necessity. One didn't need it to lead a fulfilling life. Indeed,